THREE

Reconciliation

NELL · DAY 23,200 · TUESDAY 21 APRIL 2026

I HAD NINE days of notice left, twelve ledgers, and a keycard that still worked.

The keycard beeped. I looked up before I could stop myself. The red light was on, in its corner above the door, where it had presumably been for years. I went in under it and pulled the roller door down behind me.

A manifest can be doctored. A vehicle log is a different animal. Every lorry, every day: driver, mileage out, mileage in, a one-line job reference, written by men who were tired and wanted to go home. It's the kind of paperwork that only lies about small things. If a lorry had gone to Harrowgate House in 1971, a tired man had written down where.

The 1971 logs were three shelves below the box where I'd found the manifest, in ledgers with marbled covers gone soft as felt. I took down January. Then February. I didn't sit on the crate; I worked standing at the shelf, the ledger open on my forearm, running a finger down the job references. Depot. Depot. Port. Supermarket. Depot.

I didn't stop for lunch. At three a lorry went past on the road outside and I lost my place and had to go back a week. At five the strip light flickered and I worked through it.

March.

Wednesday the third. A round trip, logged in a careful hand, with no job reference at all. Where the reference belonged, he'd written *H.H. — per instr.*

The mileage put the far end about two and a half hours away. Somewhere rural. Somewhere you'd need instructions to find.

I stood very still with the ledger on my arm. Harrowgate House. Per instruction. One run in a whole quarter of runs, to the place on my manifest, and nobody had billed it.

I wrote the date on the back of my hand, because there was nothing else to write on, and put March back on the shelf.

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BY THEN THE blog had readers.

Eleven on the first day. I knew because the platform shows you a small grey number at the top of the screen, and I refreshed it while my toast burned. Thirteen. One of them was almost certainly me on my phone. By the end of the week it was four hundred, and I couldn't have told you how.

There were comments. A man in a city I'd never been to explained, at length and with great confidence, that the stamp was obviously a brand of Victorian fertiliser. A woman wrote just *I believe you*, and I didn't know what to do with that, because I hadn't claimed anything. One stranger offered, politely, to have me sectioned.

And on the Friday, a reader with a cartoon owl for a picture wrote one line:

Could D. 3062 be a count of days? Like a ship's log?

I said *oh* out loud, at the kitchen counter, in the voice you use when your glasses turn out to be on your head. I'd spent eleven years with dates. A stranger with an owl had seen it in a morning.

I was annoyed. I want that on the record.

Then I sat down at the kitchen table with a pencil and the back of an envelope. If the third of March 1971 was day 3,062, then day nought was 3,062 days before it. Years first, then the leap years, then the months, then the remainder, each line checked before I trusted the next. Then again on my phone. Then, because I no longer trusted anything I'd only checked twice, by hand again.

The fourteenth of October, 1962.

Somebody had started counting a week before the world held its breath. And somebody had still been counting, carefully, eight years and four months later.

Anyone old enough remembers that autumn, and everyone younger has seen the documentaries: the week the whole world sat in front of its radios and waited to find out whether there would be a next week. I didn't write about it. I sat at my kitchen table with the envelope, and felt something very old and very cold go down the back of my neck.

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ON THE SUNDAY I walked past the old head office, because my feet decided to.

It's flats now, near the goods yard: the lettering chiselled off the stone, the windows replaced with the kind that don't open. My father worked on the second floor for thirty years. If you'd asked anyone at Coyle's where a document was, in any year between 1979 and 2009, they'd have said *ask Emmanuel*, and he'd have taken off his reading glasses and told you the shelf, the box, and probably the colour of the folder.

He did the crossword in pen, every evening, and never once crossed anything out. He'd have done my sum in his head before the kettle boiled. He'd have known about the 1971 logs. He'd have known which drivers did the runs that never went on the board.

I stood across the road with my bag on my shoulder and took out my phone to ring him.

I got as far as his name before I remembered. Seven years, and it still happens: a half-second where he's alive, and then the floor goes. I've never deleted the number. I don't know who has it now. Some days I think about ringing it to find out, and some days I'm afraid someone will answer.

I put the phone away and walked home the long way.

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THERE WERE TWO retired drivers I still had numbers for. On the Monday I rang them both.

The first one laughed. *Long weather? Sounds like my ex-wife.* He'd never heard of it, and I believed him, and we talked about his allotment for twenty minutes instead.

The second one went quiet.

I'll call him Len, which is nothing like his name. He'd driven for Coyle's for forty-six years and retired the year I joined. When I said *for the long weather* there was a silence long enough that I thought the line had gone. Then he said he'd meet me for a coffee, but not at his house. "The caff by the old depot. Thursday. Ten." He rang off before I could thank him.

Thursday was the last day of my notice. Nobody asked for the keycard back, and I didn't offer it.

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THE CAFÉ BY the old depot has been about to close since 1985. Formica tables, a laminated menu with photographs the food has never lived up to, a radio playing to itself. Len was already there, in the corner seat with his back to the wall, and I understood without being told that he'd chosen it.

He was a big man gone thin: the frame still there, the weight gone somewhere else. He had a mug of tea in both hands and a driver's habits he'd never put down. He'd parked facing out. He'd taken the seat that saw the door. When I sat, he moved the sugar so it wasn't between us, as if clearing a cab for a passenger. When I

slid my phone across with the photo of the manifest, he didn't look at it for a long time. Then he held it at arm's length, the way people hold photographs of the dead.

"Twice a year, maybe," he said. "Never on the board. The office'd ring you at home the night before. You'd not get the job sheet in the cab. You'd collect, you'd deliver, and a fella'd meet you at the far end and pay you, separate. Cash. Polite. Good suit. You'd not remember his face after. Not a bad face. Just one that didn't stick."

He turned the phone face down on the table, gently, as if it might wake.

I asked what he'd carried.

"Machines, mostly." Teletypes, early on. Later, "them fax things". And once, in the eighties, something the size of a wardrobe, in a crate, that took four men to lift, out to the country house the old drivers called H.H. "And it hummed," he said. "With the power off. You could feel it through the seat. Like a fridge, but there was no plug on it." He heard himself say it, and looked at his tea as if the tea had been talking. "I'm probably remembering it wrong."

The door opened.

A man came in and sat at the table next to ours. Ordinary height, an ordinary coat, a newspaper folded under his arm that he put on the table and didn't open. He ordered a tea. He said please and thank you. He sat facing the window, half turned from us, and looked at the street as if he were waiting for a bus that might not come.

Len stopped talking.

He didn't look at the man. He picked up the laminated menu and read it, carefully, though he'd have known it by heart for forty years. Then he asked me whether my mum was keeping well. I told him she'd died, ten years ago. He said he was sorry, he hadn't known, and then he told me about his allotment, the same allotment I'd heard about on Monday from the other driver, or one ex-

actly like it, and I let him, because something in his face had shut like a door.

The man drank his tea. It took about ten minutes. He left a coin on the saucer, picked up his unopened paper and went out, and the bell over the door rang behind him.

Len didn't turn round. He watched the window instead, the dark strip of it beside the door where the street showed back to front, until the coat had gone past it and out of the frame. Then he watched a little longer, in case it came back.

It didn't. Nobody got on a bus. There wasn't a stop on that side of the road.

Len put the menu down.

"Did you know him?" I said.

"Who?"

I looked at him. He looked back, quite steadily.

"Never seen him before," he said. "Couldn't tell you what he looked like."

Neither could I. I tried, later, in the car, with my notebook on the steering wheel, the way I'd describe a load for a manifest: height, build, colour, distinguishing marks. A coat. A newspaper. Please and thank you. I sat with the pen over the page for a long time. That was all I had.

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I ASKED LEN about the first run. Harrowgate. 1962.

"Before my time, that one. Old Tommy did it." Len turned his mug a quarter-turn. "First one, they reckoned. Never talked about it, not for years. Then when he got old he never talked about anything else. We thought he'd gone soft."

"What did he say?"

"Same thing, every time. Took a machine out to a big house in the fog, on a Saturday. Seven cars on the drive and no staff to park them. Fella at the door, no face to speak of, says it'll be *needed from tomorrow*." Len shook his head. "Tommy said he wrote that

on the docket. Didn't need to. Nobody'd asked him. Wrote it down so it'd be somewhere, he said, because it bothered him and he'd nowhere else to put it."

I didn't say anything. I'd been carrying that house around in my bag for ten days, and here, at last, was somebody in it: a young man in a cab, in 1962, with a pencil, putting a thing that bothered him on the only paper he had. Sixty-four years later a stranger was hearing it in a café, from a man who'd heard it from a man who'd gone soft.

Needed from tomorrow. A machine carried into that house on the Saturday. The counting started on the Sunday.

"Died, what, ten years since," Len said. "I didn't go to the funeral. Should have."

A man with no face at the door in 1962. A cash man whose face didn't stick in the eighties. Two drivers, twenty years apart, describing the same man, or the same kind of man, which I found I liked even less. I thought about the man at the next table, and his paper that he never opened, and then I made myself stop.

So I asked Len why he'd gone quiet on the phone.

He lined his mug up with the edge of the table, like a man squaring a stack of paper.

"Because my mate Terry asked," he said. "Back in the eighties. Asked the office who the cash man was. Just asked. Friendly, like. And then Terry wasn't on long-distance any more. Nothing nasty. Nobody shouted. He just never got the good runs again. Local stuff till he retired. Never knew why, and never asked anything else, ever." A quarter-turn of the mug. "Lucky, really, Terry. Lost the good runs and kept his sleep."

He looked at me then, properly, for the first time.

"You notice that sort of thing. You notice it for forty years."

He stood up and put on his coat, which took a while, and left a two-pound coin for his tea even though I'd said I'd pay. At the door he turned round, and I thought he was going to say goodbye.

“You’ll notice it too, now,” he said. “That’s what I’m telling you, love. Once you’ve seen it, that’s you. That’s the rest of your life.”

The bell rang. The radio played to itself. I sat with a cold coffee and my phone face down on the Formica, and I understood that he hadn’t been warning me off.

He’d been welcoming me.